

Epistemic Decolonization in the 21st Century: Deconstructing AI, Big Data, And Global Knowledge Systems

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Abstract

Despite promises of technological neutrality, the digital revolution often reproduces—and sometimes intensifies—historical patterns of inequality and exclusion. This paper investigates how artificial intelligence (AI), big data, and global knowledge infrastructures continue to reflect and reinforce colonial hierarchies, frequently sidelining non-Western epistemologies and communities. Grounded in decolonial theory, the analysis draws on diverse case studies, including the MASAKHANE project for African language AI, Indigenous-led data sovereignty initiatives, and policy debates in the Global South, to illustrate both the persistence of digital coloniality and the rise of innovative local resistance.

By mapping how data extraction, algorithmic bias, and the epistemic marginalization of minority cultures are embedded in contemporary digital systems, the research reveals the limitations of technical "fixes" and argues for a more fundamental transformation of digital governance. The paper advances a framework for epistemic decolonization that foregrounds pluralism, community control, and the recognition of multiple knowledge systems in technology design and policy. Policy recommendations are offered to support collective data governance, participatory AI development, and capacity building in underrepresented regions. Ultimately, the study calls for a reimagining of digital futures in which justice, inclusion, and epistemic diversity are central—not peripheral—to technological progress. This approach has broad implications for scholars, practitioners, and policymakers seeking to build more equitable, plural, and sustainable digital societies.

Key words: epistemic decolonization, algorithmic coloniality, data sovereignty, Artificial Intelligence, knowledge systems

J.E.L. classification: B52, O33, Z13, D83, L86

1. Introduction

Recent years have seen renewed public soul-searching about the legacy of colonialism, most visibly through activism aimed at rethinking monuments and school curricula. Yet, in these heated debates, it is striking how rarely the conversation turns to technology. While many commentators dissect political and economic legacies, the invisible hand of digital platforms and algorithms slips largely under the radar. Addressing current inequities, I argue, requires us to recognize how technologies both reflect and reshape the power structures they supposedly transcend. Despite persistent claims about the objectivity of artificial intelligence (AI) and big data (Roberts et al., 2023), these technologies are not created in a vacuum.

Their logics are shaped by the histories, assumptions, and priorities of those who design and deploy them (Barrett et al., 2025). The fantasy of "digital silence"—where code and data float above history—remains a barrier to honest analysis (Ford et al., 2025). This paper brings decolonial theory to bear on the digital present, showing how algorithms and infrastructures inherit and amplify colonial logics. Consider the MASAKHANE project, which builds African-language AI: it is not simply an act of technical innovation, but a challenge to the epistemic dominance of English and the marginalization of African knowledge. Here, "epistemic decolonization" means reviving and legitimizing ways of knowing that were actively suppressed by colonial rule (Mignolo, 2011). The stakes go beyond technical fairness—what's at issue is who gets to define knowledge, whose voices and values are built into the systems that increasingly shape the world. With these questions in mind, this study traces how digital power operates through epistemic colonialism, explores pathways of resistance, and proposes principles for a genuinely inclusive digital future.

2. Literature review

Foundations of epistemic colonialism: The imperialism of knowledge. Colonial conquest was never just about territory; it was equally an assault on meaning. Quijano (2007) argues that the "coloniality of power" outlasted empires, continuing to shape how race and knowledge are constructed. The philosophical toolkit of colonialism—Cartesian dualism, faith in progress, the pretense of universality (Mignolo, 2011)—has long privileged certain ways of knowing while actively discrediting or erasing others. For Indigenous peoples, knowledge, language, and culture were not simply ignored but systematically declared irrational or "myth," a process Santos (2018) calls "epistemicide." Colonial institutions, from museums to census bureaus, did not just describe the world—they invented the categories that justified domination, fixing the Global South as object of study, never author (Said, 1978).

The political economy of knowledge production: The modern university as a neo-colonial site. Epistemic colonialism's influence persists in shaping modern knowledge systems. Despite espousing ideals of universality, contemporary universities continue to prioritize Western intellectual traditions, thereby sustaining what has been termed the "coloniality of knowledge" (Grosfoguel, 2013). This is reflected in the predominance of Western academic journals and publishing houses, as well as prestige metrics that disproportionately benefit institutions in the Global North (Bellen et al., 2024). Student migration from the Global South to the Global North perpetuates patterns of intellectual dependency, reinforcing hierarchical relationships (Keet, 2014). Development paradigms often serve as forms of "epistemic charity," imposing Western frameworks as universal solutions to problems defined through Western perspectives (Escobar, 2018). In the digital era, these hierarchical dynamics are further entrenched. Practices such as "open data" and "knowledge transfer" can replicate extractive relationships, where data is sourced from the Global South while value creation and analytic power remain concentrated in the Global North (Thatcher et al., 2016).

The critical turn in Tech studies and its decolonial limit. Recent critical work in technology studies—by scholars such as O'Neil (2016) and Eubanks (2018)—has exposed how algorithms reinforce social inequalities.

The FAccT movement has made bias visible and measurable (Barocas et al., 2019). Yet, even these critiques often remain within a Western liberal frame, focusing on fairness without questioning the deeper assumption that all human life should be turned into data (Birhane, 2020; Mohamed et al., 2020). This paper argues for a more ambitious decolonial critique—one that challenges the epistemic foundations of the digital age itself.

3. Research methodology

This study is anchored in a decolonial approach that interrogates the deep histories and philosophies shaping digital technology. Rather than tinkering at the margins, it asks foundational questions about the criteria by which knowledge is recognized and valued. Three central concepts provide the backbone:

Digital Episteme: The impulse to reduce all life to quantifiable data is now pervasive—from social media “likes” to analytics that flatten our emotional worlds (Vargas-Solar & Genoveva, 2022). This worldview privileges what can be counted over what can be lived. The extent of this impulse can be measured by the scope of daily activities now captured and analyzed by digital platforms.

Coded Coloniality: Digital systems not only mirror but often magnify the discriminatory logics of colonial rule. The persistent failure of facial recognition for people of color is not a technical glitch but a symptom of deeper, historically-rooted exclusion (Benjamin, 2019; Buolamwini & Gebru, 2018). Disparities in algorithmic outcomes reveal the ongoing force of coded coloniality.

Data Colonialism and Epistemic Dispossession: Data is routinely extracted from communities without their knowledge or benefit (Couldry & Mejias, 2019). Real justice requires asking not just who is studied, but who controls and benefits from knowledge production.

By grounding these key concepts in lived examples, clarified definitions, and measurable indicators, the framework offers a robust, actionable basis for analyzing digital coloniality.

To advance from conceptual critique to real-world impact, this research advocates for empirical approaches and practical strategies to operationalize decolonial principles:

Empirical Methods:

Participatory Action Research (PAR): Work directly with affected communities (e.g., Indigenous data stewards, local language advocates) to co-design research questions and methodologies. Example: MASAKHANE’s collaborative language model development involves local experts at every stage.

- **Mixed-Methods Case Studies:** Integrate qualitative interviews, ethnographic observation, and quantitative surveys to capture both lived experience and measurable outcomes of algorithmic harm or resistance. Example: Assessing both user narratives and usage metrics for Indigenous knowledge-sharing platforms.

- **Algorithmic Auditing:** Conduct systematic, independent audits of AI and data systems to reveal bias, epistemic exclusion, or power asymmetries. Example: Annual disparity analyses of facial recognition technologies in public sector use.

Practical Implementation:

- **Community Data Governance:** Establish local advisory boards and grant them veto power over data collection, use, and sharing. Example: Indigenous OCAP® principles in health data projects ensure community ownership and approval.

- **Capacity Building:** Create training programs and open-source resources for underrepresented communities in AI and data science. Host regular hackathons focused on developing open-source tools for marginalized languages, tracking participation and outcomes.

- **Policy Integration:** Work with government and multilateral bodies to embed decolonial and epistemic justice metrics into digital policies and procurement. Example: Require that public sector AI deployments publicly report on community participation and epistemic diversity.

These empirical and practical strategies enable systematic measurement of progress toward epistemic decolonization, grounding policy and research in the lived realities and aspirations of diverse communities.

Analytical Approach. This study’s analytical approach blends decolonial theory (Quijano, 2007; Mignolo, 2011; Santos, 2018) with critical research on technology (O’Neil, 2016; Crawford, 2021) by employing a dual strategy. First, it uses conceptual mapping to trace how colonial logics and hierarchies become embedded in the design and deployment of AI and big data systems. Mignolo’s (2011) concept of the “colonial matrix of power” is central to revealing the continuities between historical and digital forms of epistemic dominance. Second, the analysis draws on thematic investigation of real-world cases—such as algorithmic discrimination in public services or resistance movements in the Global South—paying particular attention to how these cases illuminate power relations in political economy, bias, and infrastructure. Rather than treating examples from the Global South as peripheral, this methodology places them at the core of knowledge production. The approach is committed to pluriversality: it recognizes the legitimacy of multiple knowledge traditions and explicitly challenges the universalizing tendencies of Western techno-scientific norms.

4. Findings

4.1. Three pillars of digital coloniality

Pillar 1: The political economy of data extraction

The global hunger for data echoes the exploitative patterns of colonial resource extraction. Data is not only the "new oil"—it is the core resource of the digital economy, with flows from the Global South to the Global North reinforcing old hierarchies. Humanitarian organizations, sometimes under the banner of "efficiency," gather sensitive biometric data from refugees, raising complex questions about consent and ownership. "Free" platforms entice users with convenience, only to monetize their information. Infrastructure remains concentrated in the North, ensuring that value and power flow upward while communities in the South are reduced to raw data sources. This is digital enclosure—an old logic in a new guise.

Pillar 2: Algorithmic bias as epistemic violence

Algorithmic "bias" is not just a bug to be fixed; it is a form of epistemic violence rooted in histories of classification and exclusion. AI trained on Western-dominated data reproduces—and sometimes intensifies—the marginalization of other worldviews. Predictive policing tools in the United States have assigned higher risk to African-American defendants, perpetuating cycles of injustice. Facial recognition systems routinely fail with darker-skinned faces.

These are not mere technical errors, but signs of who is allowed to be visible, and whose realities are systematically erased. Coded coloniality lives on.

Pillar 3: The digital divide as epistemic marginalization

The real "digital divide" is not just about access to hardware or connectivity. It is about who gets to define the digital world—whose languages, cultures, and knowledge are embedded, and whose are left out. With less than 1% of online content in African languages, vast cultural worlds remain invisible. The dominance of English in code and infrastructure shapes what is possible, setting the terms for what counts as knowledge. This marginalization is not accidental; it is a product of design and institutional choices. Further, the lack of diversity in the technology workforce—especially in influential tech hubs like Silicon Valley—means that products and platforms are often created through the lens of a narrow demographic, perpetuating exclusionary practices (Broussard, 2018). Another dimension of this divide is the imposition of Western-designed technological "solutions" onto contexts for which they were not intended, sidelining local expertise, cultural values, and social realities (Talhouk et al., 2021; Mollema & T., 2024). The consequence is a digital form of epistemicide, where entire knowledge systems and cultural perspectives are rendered invisible, restricting the construction of digital futures to a single, dominant worldview instead of embracing a diversity of epistemologies (Mollema & T., 2024).

4.2. Pathways to decolonization

Data sovereignty as collective self-determination

The struggle for digital justice begins with the recognition that data is not just an individual asset, but a collective resource bound up with cultural identity and community autonomy. Unlike privacy regimes that focus solely on personal consent, data sovereignty asserts the right of communities to determine how information about their members, lands, and practices is gathered, stored, and shared. The Māori-led Te Mana Rauunga initiative in New Zealand offers a powerful example: by embedding Indigenous values into data governance, it challenges the presumption that global standards are universally applicable. Similar efforts around the globe—such as the adoption of the CARE Principles and the OCAP® framework—demonstrate that authentic data sovereignty is measurable, not only by the presence of policy but by the number of digital projects meaningfully governed by the communities they represent. In the African context, debates over Kenya's Huduma Namba system reveal both the promise and the pitfalls of localizing control in the face of corporate and state interests. Ultimately, these efforts mark an ongoing negotiation over what it means to reclaim digital self-determination.

Indigenous AI and the pluriversal digital future

A crucial pathway to digital decolonization is the creation of Indigenous and community-driven artificial intelligence—technologies designed from the ground up to reflect non-Western ways of knowing and local cultural values (Mohamed et al., 2020). Rather than simply adapting Western technologies for new contexts, this approach prioritizes the development of data sets and AI models that are rooted in the languages, histories, and ecological knowledge of the communities they are meant to serve (Roberts et al., 2023; Asiedu et al., 2024). For example, AI tools can be purpose-built to document and revitalize oral traditions, or to support land and resource management based on traditional ecological practices (Lewis et al., 2021; Jacob et al., 2018).

This vision embodies the principle of pluriversality, echoing the Zapatista philosophy of "a world where many worlds fit" (Escobar, 2018).

In this framework, a truly just digital future is not a single, universal model imposed on all, but a constellation of distinct technological worlds—each grounded in the knowledge systems and aspirations of its own community (Barrett et al., 2025). The challenge, then, is not to localize Western technology, but to foster genuinely new digital imaginaries that emerge authentically from Indigenous and marginalized traditions. Progress toward this goal can be measured by the degree to which digital infrastructures, educational content, and policy frameworks explicitly include and are shaped by non-Western epistemologies. Ultimately, the struggle for epistemic justice in AI is inseparable from broader efforts to recognize and empower diverse knowledge systems in shaping the future. The strength of the decolonial framework advanced here lies in its ability to explain persistent forms of algorithmic and data-driven harm that conventional technical fairness approaches frequently fail to address. By foregrounding the historical and political origins of digital power, the analysis demonstrates why technical fixes are often inadequate for achieving genuine justice. The robustness of the study's claims is further supported by drawing upon empirical evidence and case studies from the Global South, treating these as central, not peripheral, to the theorization of digital coloniality (Asiedu et al., 2024).

5. Conclusions

Limitations of the study: This research is subject to several limitations. First, the analysis is primarily conceptual and relies on secondary data, which may not capture the most recent or localized forms of resistance and innovation. Second, the formidable resource requirements for developing competitive AI systems mean that local or alternative projects often remain on the margins, with limited influence on dominant technological trends. Third, there is a structural tension between the pursuit of data sovereignty and the practical benefits of global digital interconnection, which can complicate decolonial goals. Finally, efforts by actors in the Global North to "include" marginalized voices risk perpetuating paternalistic relationships, sometimes reducing genuine pluriversality to mere tokenism (D'Ignazio & Klein, 2020).

Generalizability and future research: The analytical framework presented is applicable to any context where Western technological standards are imposed on non-Western epistemologies. Future research should be as plural and participatory as the visions for digital justice it aims to support. Three main avenues are proposed: (1) ethnographic and participatory studies of data sovereignty initiatives, with attention to governance and practical challenges; (2) technical research focused on developing AI and data infrastructures that are culturally and linguistically inclusive, especially for marginalized groups; and (3) policy and legal analysis that contributes to the design of global governance models prioritizing epistemic justice and data sovereignty.

The broader aim is not to reject technological progress, but to democratize and pluralize its development through collective, bottom-up processes.

Policy recommendations: To address the enduring effects of epistemic coloniality within artificial intelligence, big data, and global knowledge systems, the following policy recommendations are proposed:

1. **Strengthen Community Data Governance:** National and international frameworks should explicitly recognize and support collective data rights for Indigenous, local, and historically marginalized communities.

Legal mechanisms must empower these groups to exercise meaningful authority over the collection, storage, use, and distribution of data derived from their knowledge, identities, and territories.

2. Mandate Pluriversal AI Design: Regulatory bodies should require that AI systems, especially those deployed in multicultural and multilingual contexts, incorporate input from a broad spectrum of epistemic traditions. This includes funding for the development of datasets and algorithms that represent diverse cultural logics and languages, as well as the establishment of participatory design processes. Example: The MASAKHANE project demonstrates collaborative development of NLP models for African languages, centering local knowledge and language expertise in AI. Metric: Measure the proportion of AI projects that include participatory co-design with representatives from at least three distinct epistemic or cultural communities.

3. Enforce Algorithmic Transparency and Accountability: All entities developing or deploying AI and data-driven technologies must be obligated to conduct independent audits for bias, discrimination, and epistemic exclusion. Audit results should be made publicly accessible, and there must be clear remediation pathways for affected groups. Example: The Gender Shades project (Buolamwini & Gebru, 2018) set a benchmark for independent algorithmic audits, revealing bias in commercial facial analysis systems and prompting industry reform. Metric: Require annual public reporting of audit outcomes and remediation steps, and track the number of bias incidents identified and addressed per year.

4. Incentivize Capacity Building in the Global South: Investment in research, infrastructure, and education must be directed towards institutions and communities in the Global South to foster autonomous technological development. This includes support for local cloud infrastructure, open-source tools, and multilingual educational resources. Example: The African Institute for Mathematical Sciences (AIMS) is a pan-African network that builds research capacity and trains scientists from across the continent. Metric: Monitor year-on-year growth in local R&D funding, the number of locally led tech projects, and the increase in STEM graduates from Global South institutions.

5. Promote International Norms for Epistemic Justice: Multilateral organizations should adopt and enforce guidelines that prioritize epistemic justice in technology governance. This involves integrating the principles of data sovereignty, cultural self-determination, and the recognition of multiple knowledge systems into global standards for digital innovation. Example: The United Nations Permanent Forum on Indigenous Issues (UNPFII) works to embed Indigenous perspectives and epistemologies in global policy discussions. Metric: Track the number of international agreements and standards that include explicit language on epistemic justice and cultural pluralism.

Implementing these policy recommendations is necessary for redressing structural inequities and advancing a more just, inclusive, and pluralistic digital future (Mohamed et al., 2020; Abdilla et al., 2023; Kukutai & Taylor, 2016).

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